

Renovation & Extension Planning Guide

Plan it right the first time — avoid the costly mistakes most homeowners make

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From a licensed builder with 40 years of experience. Most renovation disasters happen before a single tool is picked up — poor planning, wrong quotes, missing permits. This guide gives you the insider knowledge to plan smart, budget accurately, and deal with trades like a professional.

PHASE 1 — SCOPE & PLANNING

	ACTION ITEM
✓	Define scope clearly in writing before approaching any trades
✓	Check local council — does this require DA approval?
✓	Get a private certifier quote for CDC (faster than DA in most cases)
✓	Check if property has a heritage overlay or easements
✓	Confirm structural implications — is any wall load-bearing?
✓	Identify asbestos risk (pre-1990 homes) — get tested before disturbing
✓	Measure twice — draw rough floor plans before briefing anyone

PHASE 2 — BUDGET & QUOTES

	ACTION ITEM
✓	Get minimum 3 quotes for all major trades
✓	Add 15-20% contingency to every budget — always
✓	Ask: is this quote fixed-price or cost-plus? (always prefer fixed)
✓	Check quote includes ALL materials, not just labour
✓	Verify all trades are licensed — QBCC licence check online (free)
✓	Check insurance — public liability AND home warranty
✓	Confirm payment schedule — never pay more than 10% upfront
✓	Ask for a signed contract — verbal agreements are worthless

PHASE 3 — DURING CONSTRUCTION

	ACTION ITEM
✓	Take dated photos of every stage — especially before covering up
✓	Keep a daily diary of what trades were on site and what was done
✓	Never pay progress claims for work not yet done
✓	Inspect framing BEFORE plasterboard goes up
✓	Test all wet area waterproofing BEFORE tiling
✓	Raise defects in writing immediately — not verbally
✓	Don't let builder sub out without your knowledge

✓	Keep a punch list — running list of unresolved items
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PHASE 4 — COMPLETION & SIGN-OFF

	ACTION ITEM
✓	Do not make final payment until ALL defects rectified
✓	Sighted all compliance certificates before sign-off
✓	Test every switch, tap, door and window yourself
✓	Get all warranty cards and manuals for appliances
✓	Take final dated photos of all completed areas
✓	Retain all contracts, approvals, receipts — store digitally

QUEENSLAND PERMIT QUICK GUIDE

	ACTION ITEM
✓	Adding a deck >2.4m high → Building Permit required
✓	Retaining wall >1m → Engineering + Permit
✓	New wet area (bathroom/kitchen) → Plumbing Permit
✓	New electrical circuits → Electrical Permit
✓	Pool or spa → Pool Safety Compliance required
✓	Granny flat → DA or CDC + Plumbing + Electrical
✓	Structural changes (remove walls) → Engineering + Building Permit